

- RAG Learning

1.7 Elections and Referendums

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 1 (Government and Politics of the UK)

The UK uses **four different electoral systems** across its various elections, which makes it an unusually good natural experiment: the same electorate produces two-party politics under FPTP and multi-party politics under proportional systems. That contrast is the single most useful piece of evidence in this topic.

1. First Past the Post (Westminster)

How it works

- 650 single-member constituencies; one vote each, marked with an X.
- The candidate with the **most** votes wins — a plurality, not necessarily a majority.
- No second round, no transfers.
- The party with most seats normally forms the government.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Strong, decisive government — usually manufactures a single-party majority, so a manifesto can be implemented without post-election bargaining	Disproportional — seat share diverges sharply from vote share; governments take office on 35–44 per cent of the vote
Clear accountability — voters know at the moment of voting which programme they are choosing and whom to blame later	Wasted votes — votes for losing candidates, and the winner's surplus, have no effect

Simple — easily understood; results known quickly	Safe seats — most results are effectively predetermined, depressing turnout and concentrating campaigning on marginals
Constituency link — one identifiable MP accountable for each area	Tactical voting — voters pushed away from genuine first preferences
Excludes extremists with dispersed support	Barrier to new parties — entrenches the two main parties

Exam Tip: The **2015 general election** is the definitive illustration and should appear in any FPTP answer. UKIP won around **3.9 million votes and one seat**; the SNP won around **1.5 million votes and 56 seats**. The difference is not how many votes but *where* they were: FPTP rewards geographically concentrated support and penalises support spread evenly.

2. The other systems

Additional Member System (AMS) — Scottish Parliament, London Assembly (Senedd until 2026)

- **Hybrid:** two votes — one for a constituency member elected by FPTP, one for a regional party list.
- List seats are allocated by a corrective formula accounting for constituency seats already won, so under-represented parties receive proportionately more.
- **Strength:** retains a single identifiable constituency member while producing broadly proportional overall results.
- **Weakness:** creates two classes of representative; coalition or minority government is the norm.

Single Transferable Vote (STV) — Northern Ireland Assembly and local elections, Scottish local elections

- Multi-member constituencies; voters rank candidates in order of preference.

- Candidates reaching a quota are elected; surpluses and eliminated candidates' votes transfer.
- **Strength:** highly proportional; very few wasted votes; voters can choose between candidates of the same party. Chosen for Northern Ireland precisely to guarantee both communities representation.
- **Weakness:** large multi-member constituencies dilute the link to a single representative; counting is complex and slow.

Supplementary Vote (SV)

- Voters mark a first and second preference. If no candidate wins an absolute majority, all but the top two are eliminated and second preferences transferred.
- Used for the Mayor of London, other directly elected mayors and Police and Crime Commissioners — **changed to FPTP** by the Elections Act 2022, then **restored** by the English Devolution and Community Empowerment Act 2026.
- **Strength:** the winner has broader support than a bare plurality. **Weakness:** not proportional; second preferences for eliminated candidates are discarded.

3. Comparing outcomes

The key analytical point: **electoral systems shape party systems rather than merely reflecting them.**

- Westminster under FPTP: two-party dominance, single-party majority government.
- Scotland (and Wales until 2026) under AMS: multi-party systems, coalition and minority governments, representation for Greens and others.
- Northern Ireland under STV: representation for both communities and for smaller parties.

The same voters behave differently under different rules — splitting tickets and supporting smaller parties where the system rewards it. That is strong evidence against the argument that FPTP simply reflects an inherently two-party electorate.

4. The electoral reform debate

For reform	Against reform
FPTP produces governments unrepresentative of how the country voted	PR moves the choice of governing programme from voters to post-election coalition bargaining
Millions of votes are wasted; safe seats depress turnout	Coalitions give small parties leverage disproportionate to their support
Devolved experience shows proportional systems produce workable government	Weakens or destroys the single-member constituency link
Comparative evidence associates PR with higher turnout	FPTP delivers decisive government able to implement a manifesto

The 2011 AV referendum

- Held under the coalition agreement. Result: roughly **68 per cent No**, on a turnout of around 42 per cent.
- AV is *not* a proportional system, so reformers were divided and campaigned unenthusiastically.
- Effect: removed electoral reform from the agenda for a generation.

Exam Tip: The most persuasive explanation for why reform has stalled is **rational, not philosophical**: the parties with the power to legislate are precisely those FPTP advantages. Neither main party has an incentive to abolish the system that delivers it majorities on a minority of the vote.

5. Referendums

Referendum — a vote in which the electorate accepts or rejects a particular proposal, usually on a single constitutional or sovereignty question. In the UK the result is **advisory in law**, because Parliament is sovereign — but politically binding in practice.

Year	Referendum	Result
1975	Continued EEC membership	~67% Yes
1997	Scottish and Welsh devolution	Yes in both
1998	Good Friday Agreement	~71% Yes in NI
2011	Alternative Vote	~68% No
2011	Further Welsh law-making powers	~63% Yes
2014	Scottish independence	55% No / 45% Yes, ~85% turnout
2016	EU membership	52% Leave / 48% Remain, ~72% turnout

Arguments for

- **Direct legitimacy for constitutional change** — changes to the framework of politics arguably require explicit popular consent, particularly in an uncoded constitution where nothing else prevents a government altering it by ordinary legislation.
- **High engagement** — 2014 and 2016 both far exceeded contemporaneous general election turnout.
- **Resolves cross-cutting issues** — Europe divided both main parties for decades, so no general election could deliver a clear verdict on it.

Arguments against

- **Binary framing** — the 2016 vote asked whether to leave without specifying what leaving meant, so it produced a majority for a direction but not for any outcome. Parliament then spent years unable to agree on implementation.
- **Clash with parliamentary sovereignty** — a legally advisory vote acquired binding political authority, while a majority of MPs had favoured Remain. The constitution offers no mechanism for resolving that conflict; the result was prorogation, litigation and an early general election.
- **No threshold** — a narrow majority on a single day can deliver irreversible constitutional change.
- **Campaign effects** — funding, media framing and differential turnout can distort outcomes.

- **They can entrench division** — neither 2014 nor 2016 settled the question it asked.
- **Motive** — referendums have often been called to manage internal party division rather than because the constitutional moment demanded it. Both 1975 and 2016 arose substantially from splits within the governing party.

6. Campaigns and voting behaviour

- **Manifestos and the mandate** — a winning party claims authority to implement its programme; this underpins the Salisbury Convention.
- **Regulation** — the Electoral Commission enforces statutory spending limits; paid political advertising on television is prohibited, which constrains the role of money far more than in the USA.
- **Dealignment** — the weakening of habitual class-based and partisan loyalties since the 1970s, making campaigns and leaders more decisive.
- **Valence** — voters increasingly judge parties on perceived competence (especially economic) and leadership rather than on ideological position.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Plurality	More votes than any other candidate, but not necessarily a majority
Wasted vote	A vote that does not contribute to electing a representative
Safe seat	A constituency where one party has a large majority and is very unlikely to lose
Marginal seat	A constituency where the result is genuinely competitive
Tactical voting	Voting for a less-preferred candidate to prevent a worse outcome

Proportional representation	Systems in which seat share broadly matches vote share
Quota (STV)	The number of votes a candidate needs to be elected
Dealignment	Weakening of habitual class-based or partisan voting loyalties
Valence	Judging parties on perceived competence rather than ideological position

Essential examples

- **2015 general election** — UKIP 3.9m votes/1 seat vs SNP 1.5m votes/56 seats.
- **2011 AV referendum** — ~68% No on ~42% turnout; reform off the agenda.
- **2014 Scottish referendum** — ~85% turnout; engagement responds to stakes.
- **2016 EU referendum** — 52/48; advisory in law, binding in practice.
- **2010 coalition** — FPTP failing to deliver a majority; post-election bargaining.
- **Elections Act 2022** — mayors and PCCs moved from SV to FPTP; voter ID introduced.
- **2026** — SV restored for mayors and PCCs; the Senedd moved to closed-list PR; the last hereditary peers left the Lords.